Currency Conversion — Which Service Should We Use?

Plain-language recommendation for Lead / Project Manager · Includes free vs paid plans

What is this about?

When a user enters an amount in Indian Rupees (INR) — or another local currency — our product must show the same value in another currency such as US Dollars (USD), UAE Dirhams (AED), or Saudi Riyals (SAR).

To do that we need a trustworthy **exchange rate** from an online service. We also need the rate for a **specific date** the user chooses (for example an invoice date), and we should **save the rate we used** so the amount does not change later.

Reference we compared against

Date: **22 Oct 2026** · Amount: **10,000 INR**

Reference	US Dollars (USD)	UAE Dirhams (AED)
Original / expected mid-market	105.43	388.90

Services we researched

1. **Open Exchange Rates** — https://openexchangerates.org/
2. **ExchangeRate-API** — https://www.exchangerate-api.com/
3. **CurrencyAPI / free community feeds** — demos only, not for a company product

Free versions — what we get (and limits)

Both main services offer a **free plan** that is useful for testing. Free plans are **not enough for a full production company product** if we need reliable past-date rates and higher monthly usage. Approximate free limits (check vendor sites before buying):

	Open Exchange Rates (free)	ExchangeRate-API (free)
Monthly usage (approx.)	About 1,000 requests / month	About 1,500 requests / month
What rates you get	Mostly today's / latest rates (USD as the main base currency)	Mostly today's / latest rates (pair conversion works well)
Past-date rates (e.g. invoice date)	Usually limited or paid	Not on free — needs paid plan
Good for	POC / early testing	POC / early testing
Not enough alone for	Heavy production traffic + reliable historical dates	Heavy production traffic + reliable historical dates

Bottom line on free: Free is fine to try the integration. For production we should budget for a **paid plan**. On free, ExchangeRate-API gives a few more monthly calls (~1,500 vs ~1,000). Neither free plan is a full substitute for paid historical rates.

Our recommendation

Production (paid): Open Exchange Rates.
If price is the main constraint (paid): ExchangeRate-API.
For now / testing (free): either free plan works for a POC; ExchangeRate-API free has a slightly higher monthly call limit.

Why Open Exchange Rates over ExchangeRate-API (for paid / production)

- **Past-date conversion** is stronger on their commercial plans (invoice / booking date).
- **Better fit for a company product** — clear paid service, commonly used by application backends.

- **Easier audit trail** — save the exact rate and date used on each transaction.
- **Covers INR, USD, AED, SAR** and more in one standard server-side approach.
- **Trade-off:** ExchangeRate-API felt close on USD/AED in our tests and is usually a bit cheaper; free plan also allows slightly more monthly calls. We still recommend Open Exchange Rates as the production primary, with ExchangeRate-API as the budget alternate.

Paid vs free — simple view

Topic	Open Exchange Rates	ExchangeRate-API
Free plan	~1,000 calls/month Latest rates mainly	~1,500 calls/month Latest rates mainly
Paid plan (why we need it)	Past dates + higher volume + production reliability	Past dates + higher volume + production reliability
Best role	Primary for production	Budget / alternate

Business note

For official company accounts / tax in India, we may still need **RBI or bank rates**. Online conversion services are good for the product if we save the exact rate used.

Decision asked: Approve Open Exchange Rates (paid) as primary for production. Use free plans only for testing. Keep ExchangeRate-API as the lower-cost paid alternative (and note its free plan has a slightly higher monthly call limit).

Limits above are approximate and can change — confirm on each vendor’s pricing page before purchase. Internal review note · plain language.